



THE ETHEREAL

DROWNED LIGHT & BORROWED SOULS



A GM-Ready One-Shot Campaign

FOR D&D 5E (SRD 5.2) · SYSTEM-NEUTRAL FRIENDLY · 3-5 PLAYERS

THE PITCH IN A BREATH

There is a city that keeps its dead the way other cities keep a fire: carefully, gratefully, and a little too close. It is called **Glassmere**, and it floats on a forest of black-oak stilts above a lake that does not reflect the sky. Every evening the lamps come up gold across the water, and every evening the people thank their ancestors for the light — because in Glassmere the light is the ancestors, fished from the lake at dusk and burned, lovingly, to keep the living warm.

Tonight is **Drown-tide**, the festival of that gift. Tonight a famous child went into the water and did not come back, and her lantern washed home still burning, which everyone swears cannot happen. And tonight a voice in the lake will call one of the player characters by a name they buried.

The Ethereal is an eerie, four-hour one-shot for three to five characters of 3rd to 5th level, built for **D&D 5e (SRD 5.2)** but light enough to wear any system. It is a mystery about grief, memory, and the terrible arithmetic of survival — a town that consumes its dead to keep its children alive — and it asks the players to decide, before dawn, whether that bargain may continue. There are wonders here, and dread, and not one clean answer in the lot.

Tone: eerie, melancholy, wondrous, morally raw. Horror dialed to dread, never gore. Runtime ~4 hours (scales 2–6). Complexity medium. Rated PG-13: death, grief, drowning, and the quiet machinery of exploitation; no gore, no harm to children on the page.

Other names it has gone by: *The Vespering, The Last Lit Lantern, What the Stillwater Keeps.*

WHAT THE NIGHT SHOULD FEEL LIKE

Open on beauty. The first thing the table should feel is wonder — ten thousand lanterns on black water, a city that glows like a held breath — because the horror of Glassmere is that its beauty is sincere. These are kind people. The cruelty is baked into the kindness, and the players should not be able to tell where one ends and the other begins until it is almost too late.

By the middle of the night, unease. The realization should arrive sideways: that the warmth in every window and the screaming just below hearing are the same sound. Near the climax, grief — the understanding that the dead were never the threat, that the *harvest* is, and that there is no

lever to pull that does not cost someone something they cannot get back.

What the players should *want*, by the end, is small and human: to give one drowned child back her name, and to let someone, finally, rest. What they should carry home is the question they will argue about in the parking lot: *We kept the lights on. Were we right?*

Run it warm. Lead every scene with light, water, and song. Let the people be lovable. Save your cruelty for the truth, not the townsfolk — and never let the antagonists cackle. Everyone in Glassmere is trying to be good. That is the whole problem.

FOR THE PLAYERS (SPOILER-FREE)

You come in on the last ferry before Drown-tide, the night Glassmere thanks its ancestors for the light that keeps the town alive. The stilt-city glows on a black mirror of water; lanterns drift on the lake like patient stars; the air is salt and tallow and river-lily, and the people, laughing in their mourning-white, press warm cups of cider into the hands of strangers.

A child is missing. Her lantern came home lit, and they say that is impossible.

Bring a character of 3rd to 5th level (any SRD class) who cares about something — this is a story about loss, and a heart of stone has nothing to fear here. Expect ghosts, festivals, hard choices, and almost no clean answers; what you decide will be remembered. Combat is possible but rarely the point. The real danger is what you'll come to understand.

Before we play, tell me two things about your character: one person they have lost, and one thing they never got to say.

WHAT IS ACTUALLY HAPPENING (GM ONLY)

Here is the engine beneath the festival, and you should hold all of it in your head even as you reveal almost none of it at first.

Glassmere runs on **vesperlight** — a soft, living glow refined from the residue of the dead and drawn up out of the Stillwater, which is not merely a lake but the mouth of the Ethereal, the near-side of death. The **Lamplighters' Conclave** fishes it, refines it, rations it, and has done so for three centuries. It works — the water is clean, the food keeps, the cold marsh and the things that hunt in its fog are held at bay — and it works because of a secret no more than a dozen people alive have ever been told.

The town's founder, **Aldis Vey**, the woman the faithful pray to as **Mother Vesper**, did not ascend into paradise. She walked into the lake three hundred years ago and bound her own living soul into a single lantern at the lake's heart, making herself the keel that holds the Veil steady and the wellspring the whole harvest draws from. She is still down there. She has been awake the entire time.

For most of those centuries the draw was gentle and she endured it. Then, a generation ago, the Conclave doubled the harvest to feed a growing town and a profitable export trade — the policy they call the **Quota** — and ever since, Mother Vesper has been drained faster than the dead can replenish her. As she thins, so does the Veil. The "hauntings" that frighten Glassmere are not an attack; they are leakage — the grief and memory of harvested souls seeping back through a seam that is no longer held shut.

A week ago a twelve-year-old prodigy diver named **Pip Harrow** went too deep at the dusk fishing, reached the lake's heart, and saw Mother Vesper alive. She surfaced changed — *over-lit*, half-turned to Ethereal light — carrying the truth in her body like a coal in a cupped hand. Her lantern came home still burning because the Veil is now too weak to keep what it takes. The Conclave called her drowned and confiscated the lantern. Her father refuses to believe it. He is right not to.

High Lumen Orrin Sable knows all of this and hides it, because he is convinced — not wrongly — that the truth would kill more people than the lie. The rank-and-file Lamplighters do not know; they are devout and horrified by the same hauntings as everyone else. Tonight's Drown-tide will demand the largest single harvest of the year. This year, that harvest is enough to push Mother Vesper past the edge — and if it does, the seam tears and the **Surge**, a tide of the Ethereal, rises into the lower city and drowns the living into reflections.

The players are the only people in Glassmere positioned to change any of it, precisely because they owe it nothing: no light-debt, no faith, no faction. They can move between the Conclave, the Ferrymen, and the lake's heart, and what they choose to do with the truth — surface it, bury it, free the woman in the lantern, replace her, or rebuild the bargain on consent — decides which Glassmere greets the dawn. None of those choices is free. Keeping the light costs souls; freeing the souls costs the light. Build toward a decision the table will own, not a problem they will solve.

THE WORLD: GLASSMERE

Glassmere is four thousand souls on a forest of stilts, and not a handspan of dry land beneath any of them. It stands in a cold salt-marsh where the river Mourn unravels into a delta and forgets the way to the sea, and at the marsh's heart lies the **Stillwater** — a tideless black lake that drinks the light and gives nothing back to the eye. Everything in town moves by rope-bridge or by skiff. Everything in town runs on the lake.

THE FOUNDING, AND THE LIE INSIDE IT

The story every child knows is a kindness. Three centuries ago the marsh-folk were dying of foul water and the wasting damp and the **mistwights** that come walking in the fog, and a widow named **Aldis Vey** waded into the Stillwater at dusk and did not drown. She came back with light cupped in her bare hands — the first vesperlight — and taught her neighbors to fish it from the water, and then she gave herself to the Light so that the town might live. Drown-tide is the yearly thank-you, and the Conclave are her heirs, and only they may tend her gift.

What actually happened is darker and sadder. Aldis discovered that the lake was a seam to the Ethereal, and that the dead, refined, could be made to burn. To hold the seam open and steady forever she bound her own soul into a lantern and sank it — a gift she meant with her whole heart, never once suspecting that *forever* would keep her awake at the bottom of the world for three hundred years. The myth makes the harvest holy; it makes questioning the harvest a blasphemy; and when the faithful murmur the old lamp-lighting proverb — "*Light is borrowed; pay it back kind*" — not one of them lets themselves ask: *borrowed from whom?*

WHAT THE TOWN REMEMBERS, AND WHAT IT HIDES

A lifetime ago the Conclave learned to refine vesperlight for export, and money came to the marsh, and **House Marrow** rose on the back of it. Then, a generation ago, came the Quota: to feed a growing, selling town the harvest was doubled, and the priests announced that "the Light had grown generous." That is the year, though no almanac records it so, that Mother Vesper began to starve — and the first "thin nights" and the first hushed-up stillbirths arrived with it.

The trouble has been accelerating ever since, and the town has a story to cover each symptom. Last year a week-long fog — the Foglock — let mistwights into the lower streets and killed nine; the Conclave blamed weak faith, and not the flicker in the Veil that truly opened the door. Last month three ether-divers drowned at depth with their eyes "full of light," and the deaths were filed as accidents. And a week ago **Pip Harrow**, twelve years old and the finest young diver Glassmere had produced in a generation, went down at the deep Vespering and did not come up. Three nights ago her lantern washed against the Lantern Quay

still lit — and a lit lantern *never* comes home, because the Light is meant to keep what it takes. The Conclave seized the lantern and called the girl drowned. Her father has not stopped asking why.

THE SHAPE OF THE PLACE

Picture a wheel. At the hub stands the **Vesper Hall** with its eternal Hearth-Lantern; plank-streets and rope-bridges spoke outward from it. To the north rise the dry, bright **Highdecks** and House Marrow's saltworks; to the east lies the **Lantern Quay** and the ferry that is the only way in or out; to the south, and partly *beneath* the waterline, sprawls the **Drowned Ward**, the slum of the Unlit. And to the west opens the black water itself, roped off and watched, with the lake's heart somewhere far below it. Cut a single bridge and you strand a whole district; this is a city where a chase runs vertical and wet, and where isolation is a weapon.

The marsh gives one thing of worth, and the whole of Glassmere depends on it: vesperlight cleans the water, keeps the food, warms the houses, and holds off the Ethereal cold. Strip it away and the town has perhaps a season before the damp and the dark and the mistwights finish what they started three hundred years ago. That dependence is the bars of the cage everyone here lives inside.

HOW POWER KEEPS ITSELF

On paper a Tide Council of merchant houses and clergy makes the law, but real authority belongs to the Conclave, because the Conclave keeps the lights on. Their writ is enforced by the **Snuffers** — wardens in grey and brass who police unlicensed diving and "quench" anyone who absorbs too much vesperlight and begins to turn, the people they call the *over-lit*. The arrangement profits the Conclave, House Marrow, and the comfortable Highdeckers, and it is paid for by the Unlit of the Drowned Ward, debtors and divers' families too poor to keep a lamp lit, who live in the cold and the wet so that their betters may glow. What holds it all together is simply that the lamps *work*, and that everyone believes the dead are at peace. Prove the dead suffer, or give the town one truly dark night, and the whole edifice comes down.

BREAD, DEBT, AND THE BLACK MARKET

The town fishes, refines, salts, and sells. Coin is salt-marked metal, but for the poor the true currency is the lamp-ration, and a family will go into *light-debt* to keep a flame in the window — a debt that is inherited like a surname. The divers, the Ferrymen, take the killing risks, and those of them who go over-lit are quietly "retired." Beneath the legal trade runs a black market in smuggled raw vesperlight — *wild light*, euphoric and slowly transfiguring — and in **memory-glass**, refined light that still holds a dead person's memory, outlawed precisely

because it can be made to speak in a dead voice and prove the unprovable. For players, all of this is leverage: oil and skiffs and dive-gear to buy, a quota ledger to steal, a refinery to sabotage, a debt to forgive or to weaponize.

FAITH, CUSTOM, AND THE THINGS NOT SAID

The Cult of the Light teaches that the dead ascend into vesperlight and live on as the town's warmth, and that to be *given to the Light* is salvation; the dead are weighted and surrendered to the Stillwater so their light "comes home." Against this stands the Ferryman's whispered heresy — that the Light is a cage and the dead scream inside it. The faithful thank a lamp before snuffing it, never let a baby's first flame die, and wear *white* to mourn, because white is the color of light. They sing their drown-songs in endless overlapping rounds so that a melody never quite ends — *so no voice is ever alone* — and they teach their children two rules before any others: never let a flame die on Drown-tide, and never answer a voice from the water that knows your name. What is spiritually true here is that the dead are conscious in the Light. What is false is that they are happy. What is unknowable, and what the whole adventure turns on, is whether releasing them is mercy or murder.

You can read a person's station by how brightly their home burns: Highdeckers lit and dry, Plankfolk working and thrifty, the Unlit dim and damp. A lit taper at the door means *welcome*; an unlit one means *go*. To say someone "burns clean" is to call them honest; "may your lamp gutter" is a curse. And tonight all of it crests in Drown-tide, the festival where a costumed Vesper wades into the shallows and "returns" with light while the whole town cheers — the happiest night of the year, and a reenactment of a woman's drowning that no one will name as such.

LAW AND THE QUIET VIOLENCE

Conclave edict and Council ordinance govern, with guilt read off a suspect's sweat in a ritual dressed up as lamplight-judgment. The everyday crimes are light-theft, ration fraud, and smuggling wild light. The unforgivable ones tell you what the town truly fears: unlicensed diving in the western water, possession of memory-glass, and "false witness against the Light" — which is to say, telling the truth. Punishments run from inherited light-debt to exile in the marsh, which is often a slow death sentence; and for the worst offenders there is the **Long Snuff**, a forced over-lighting that dissolves the condemned into the Ethereal — an execution the Conclave performs as if it were an early ascension. Players who flash wild light near a Snuffer or ask the wrong question in the wrong street will meet this machinery; players who learn the rules can also

turn them, invoking a founder's right to demand audience with the Hearth-Lantern, or filing a labor grievance to stall a warden for an hour.

THE MAGIC OF THE PLACE

Vesperlight is the only sorcery most of Glassmere will ever see; true arcane magic exists but is rare and mistrusted as "borrowed fire." The Conclave holds an absolute monopoly on refining. The commons believe the light is the dead's blessing; the refiners know it decays without the lake; and only Sable's inner circle knows it is drawn from a living prisoner. It cannot raise the truly released, and it cannot be made anew without the Stillwater. In play it is everything at once — a tool, a lure, a weapon, and a tell: watch a reflection lag a half-second behind its owner, and you are watching the Veil wear thin.

THE CONTRADICTIONS THE PLAYERS CAN PULL ON

Glassmere is held together by tensions that will not resolve, and every one of them can be played. It is a religion of light that runs on the dark of the dead, so that worship and harvest are the same act. Its kindest institution is its cruelest, keeping the many alive by consuming the few. Its sainted founder is its greatest victim, venerated and tortured by one and the same devotion. Its "monsters" protect it, because the dead's leakage is also the warning that keeps the Veil from a worse and sudden tear. Its happiest festival is a drowning, and its joy depends on never asking what became of Aldis Vey. And its holiest people are its poorest — the Unlit, denied the Light, are the only souls in town not burning their own ancestors to stay warm.

THE TEXTURE OF IT

Let the senses carry the dread. There are lanterns adrift on water that gives back no reflection; mourning-white shawls drying like flags; brass gone green with verdigris; fog that glows faintly from within; and always, at the edge of sight, a reflection that moves a half-beat late. There is the lap of water under the floorboards, drown-songs folding over themselves and never ending, the soft hiss of a thanked lamp going out, a child's voice from the wrong direction, the groan of the pilings. There is salt and tallow and river-lily, eel-smoke, the ozone tang of the light, wet rope. The bread tastes faintly of metal. The cider is hot and good. And the people say *burn clean*, and *pay it back kind*, and *mind the water knows you*, and *come home lit* — and they mean every one of them as a blessing.

THE SECRET ENGINE

Everyone in Glassmere believes a comfortable thing: that the dead rise gladly into the Light, that Mother Vesper dwells in paradise, that the recent hauntings are restless

spirits lashing out at the faithful, and that Pip Harrow simply drowned. Every one of those beliefs is a wall built over the same pit.

The truth is that the Light is made of the dead, anchored and endlessly renewed by Aldis Vey, who lies awake and aware in the First Lantern at the lake's heart, and that the Quota is killing her by inches. As she fails, the Veil thins, and the dead come leaking back — which is what the town mistakes for an attack. Pip dove too deep, met her, and surfaced over-lit, carrying the truth in her changed body; her lantern returned still burning because the seam can no longer hold what it once would have kept. Inside the Conclave, only Sable and a few elders know; Maren Coil and the older Ferrymen suspect; Brother Halve at the hospice has heard it from a hundred deathbeds and said nothing, to spare the dying their peace.

The reveal is meant to surprise but never to cheat, because the truth is foreshadowed in plain sight from the first minute: the half-late reflections, the proverb about borrowed light, the white of mourning, the round-song sung *so no voice is ever alone*, the warning every child is taught about the voice in the water. A sharp table can assemble it from the air of the place; a stalled table will be carried to it by the clues. And it matters *now*, tonight, because Drown-tide demands the year's greatest harvest — the one draw large enough, this year, to finish Aldis Vey. When that lands, the players should feel the floor drop: the beautiful welcoming lights of Glassmere are a dying woman's scream, refined and poured into every window in town.

THE PRESSURE THAT DRIVES IT ALL

Three forces want three irreconcilable things, and a fourth force — time — is squeezing them all toward tonight. The **Conclave** wants the harvest to continue and the secret to stay buried, because to them stability is mercy. The **Ferrymen and the Unlit** want the harvest ended and the dead set free, even if freedom costs the lights and the comfort of the town. The **Drowned Choir** — the dead themselves, with Aldis Vey their reluctant voice — want release and remembrance, to be people again rather than fuel; but a sudden release risks tearing the Veil and drowning the living in the same motion.

Around and beneath them, the Veil is thinning and the Surge is rising on the Drown-tide, so that the true antagonist of the adventure is the clock. Ordinary people are trapped because their water, their food, and their warmth all flow from the one thing that has to stop. And the players matter for a reason no one in Glassmere can match: they are outsiders with no light-debt and no loyalty, free to walk from the Conclave's reliquary to the Ferrymen's tunnels to the lake's heart itself. The whole thing detonates the moment the Drown-tide Vespering begins — when the harvest either pushes Aldis Vey over the edge, or someone tries to stop it in front of the entire singing town.

THE POWERS OF GLASSMERE

THE LAMPLIGHTERS' CONCLAVE

They wear the brass lantern with no flame, and the town loves them, and they have earned it: they are the priest-engineers who keep four thousand people warm and fed and safe, and most of them would be horrified to learn what their order rests upon. That is the tragedy of the Conclave — its rank and file are sincere, and its inner circle is damned, and the seam between the two runs straight through the heart of **High Lumen Orrin Sable**, who knows everything and has decided, with terrible sincerity, that the few must sustain the many. Their face to outsiders is **Lumen Téa Wickham**, all brisk competence over a deepening fear. They command the refineries, the Hearth-Lantern, and the Snuffers; they hold the Highdecks and very nearly the law; and their methods are ritual, rationing, control of every story, and the quiet "retirement" of anyone who becomes inconvenient. They will want the players to find Pip and the lantern *quietly* and let Drown-tide proceed, and they can pay in coin, in forgiven debt, in legal cover, in light itself — and threaten with the Long Snuff, with exile, with a frame. Ignored, they run the great Vespering and bring on the Surge. At the climax they alone can re-anchor the Veil and hold the lights — but only by feeding it another soul. They are not villains. They are people who decided the price was worth it, and the players' job is to make them doubt it. The rumor is that Sable hasn't slept in a year; the secret is that he has knelt at the lake's heart and begged Aldis Vey's forgiveness, and she would not give it.

THE FERRYMEN, AND THE UNLIT

Their sign is an oar wrapped in black cloth, and their congregation is the half-drowned poor of the Underjetty — the divers who do the dangerous work and the families who cannot afford to glow. They are right about everything and dangerous because of it. Their leader, **Maren Coil**, was once a Lumen herself; she found the truth as a young woman and *fled* instead of fighting, and the guilt has sharpened into a blade she means to use tonight. Their gentler face is **Doran Harrow**, Pip's father, who wants nothing so grand as a revolution — only his daughter back. The union splits along exactly that line: the idealists who would end the harvest at any cost, and the parents who only want a lamp in the window and their children safe. They hold the only people who can dive, a warren of tunnels beneath the waterline, and contraband enough to prove their heresy — including the memory-glass that speaks in dead voices. They can give the players proof, dive-gear, a skiff, Pip's hiding place, and the deep-line to the lake's heart; they can threaten to blow the refinery during the festival and damn the consequences. The danger is that they are partly wrong about the cure: end the harvest too fast and the Veil tears and their own ward

drowns first. Maren, if pushed, will try to *destroy* the First Lantern outright — instant release, instant flood. The rumor says she drowned a Snuffer and smiled; the truth is that she once abandoned Mother Vesper, and everything she does now is penance.

HOUSE MARROW

A salt-coin stamped with a lantern is their mark, and prosperity is their gospel. They are the merchant family whose exported light built the modern town, and their matriarch, **Goodwife Sered Marrow**, is gracious, generous, and frightening in her practicality — a woman who balances ledgers where others would grieve. Marrow wants stability and the trade kept whole, and Sered believes with her whole flinty heart that a fed town is a quiet town. She commands money, the saltworks, the Council's ear, private muscle, and — crucially — the quota ledger whose columns quietly prove the over-harvest, which she keeps as insurance against a rainy century. She thinks the crisis is a resource problem; she does not know there is a *person* at the bottom of the lake. Her household has its own fracture: her grandson **Aldous**, sick with guilt over where the family fortune comes from, is a door the players can open. Marrow can offer the ledger for a price, money, access, evacuation, and the political weight to tip the whole town's belief; it can threaten ruin and hired knives. Ignored, Sered simply funds whoever promises stability, which usually means Sable. She is not cruel — only certain that someone has to keep the accounts. The rumor is that Marrow weighs the dead by the pound; the secret is the shrine in her private rooms to the over-lit husband she once had quietly Snuffed, and the sickness that secret has become.

THE DROWNED CHOIR

They are not an organization but a multitude — every soul the harvest ever took, conscious in the Light, grieving, and trying to be heard. To a frightened town they look like vengeful ghosts rising to drown the faithful; in truth they harm no one who will listen, and they speak through still water and through memory-glass and through the over-lit, calling names, showing memories, singing the round-song whole at last. Their voice and shepherd is **Mother Vesper** herself. What they want is simple and unbearable: to be remembered as people and let go. They can guide the players, shelter them in the Veil, and offer a true name or a wonder; they threaten nothing willingly — but a torn Veil does not choose its victims, and a sudden release drowns the living and the dead alike.

HOW THEY LEAN ON ONE ANOTHER

The Conclave and House Marrow are uneasy allies, trading money for legitimacy; the Ferrymen and the Unlit are simply kin. The open war is Conclave against Ferrymen, with Marrow and the divers' union locked in the older fight

of capital against labor. Everyone depends on the Conclave's light; the Conclave depends on the Ferryman to dive; and all of them, knowingly or not, depend on Aldis Vey, who is owed by the entire town and answered to by none of it. The seams where it can all come apart are personal: Wickham against Sable, Aldous and Sered against each other, Maren against the safety of her own

people. The levers a clever party can pull are likewise human — Sable's buried guilt, Maren's love for Doran, Sered's dead husband, Wickham's conscience. And if any faction falls, the town tilts: lose the Conclave and the lights die but the dead go free; lose the Ferryman and no one can dive and the harvest chokes anyway; lose Marrow and the economy craters and a purseless Conclave softens.

A WALK THROUGH GLASSMERE

The city is a network, not a list — six places the players will move between by bridge and skiff, and a seventh, drowned and waiting, that only opens at the end. Each entry leads with words you can read aloud, then what the place offers the people who poke at it.

THE LANTERN QUAY

The last ferry noses in through a field of lanterns that the black water refuses to reflect. Wet planks shine underfoot; brass lamps hang in their hundreds overhead; and the crowd in mourning-white parts, laughing, around a big man who is shoving toward you with a child's small lantern clutched to his chest.

This is where the players arrive and where the whole thing started, because here, three nights gone, Pip Harrow's lantern washed up still burning. It is a place of welcome and watching at once: a barker selling first-light charms, a drown-song going round, **Doran Harrow** arguing with a Lumen over his daughter, and a **Snuffer** standing very still with his eyes on the water. Linger and the players learn that Pip is missing, that her lantern came home lit, that the Conclave took it, and that lit lanterns *never* return; search the spot where it beached and they will find a shard of warm, murmuring memory-glass pressed into the planks. Beneath the quay a smuggler's skiff waits for anyone who knows the right Ferryman, and a catwalk runs down into the Drowned Ward. As the night's clock advances, the lanterns here begin to gutter in waves and the reflections lag visibly — the first cracks, if anyone is watching.

THE VESPER HALL AND ITS LUMENRY

Chant rises and falls around a single great flame — the Hearth-Lantern, warmer and somehow sadder than any other light in the city. Beneath the singing runs a low industrial hum you feel in your teeth. The air is incense laid over ozone.

The temple-refinery is the seat of the Conclave's authority and the vault of its lie. Pip's confiscated lantern sits under seal in the reliquary, alongside thirty years of suppressed "thin night" records, and the players can reach them by stealth, by a forged writ, by Wickham's quietly offered key, or under cover of the Vespering itself. The true revelation,

though, is the Hearth-Lantern: lay a hand on it and you feel her — a presence, a person, awake inside the flame. The Hall is genuinely holy and genuinely kind, which is exactly why the truth must land here hardest; the danger is sacrilege and the Snuffers, and a refinery sluice runs down from here to the lake for anyone bold enough to follow it. As the clock fills, the Hearth-Lantern dims, and the clergy who have served it all their lives begin, quietly, to be afraid.

THE STILLWATER

The lake is a black mirror, and at dusk it does not show you the sky — it shows you the other side. The surface is unnervingly still, and then, from nowhere, a round-song with no singer. The cold that comes off the water is older than weather.

The lake is the source, the seam, and the road to the heart of everything. Divers will teach the players its depth-lore; the watchful will notice that reflections here lag, and sometimes *act first*. To dive it — licensed or not — is to pass into wonder and hazard together: the cold gnaws like exhaustion, the light seeps in and threatens to over-take a careless swimmer, and the mistwights drift in the dark. But the great secret of the deep is that the mistwights *flee* the Drowned Choir rather than serve it; the dead protect the divers. Below the thermocline waits the Ethereal tide, and below that, the Lake's Heart. Dive the forbidden western water and you draw both the Snuffers and the Choir; the Ferryman's deep-line is the safer road down. As the clock fills, the lake stops keeping its distance and begins to rise through the floorboards of the whole city.

THE DROWNED WARD AND THE UNDERJETTY

Houses stand to their knees in black water. Candle-stubs gutter in windows; white laundry hangs like flags of surrender; somewhere a child counts bridge-planks aloud, over and over. It smells of mildew and eel and cheap tallow.

This is the campaign's beating heart, and the people here are to be played with dignity, never pity. The Drowned Ward is the Ferryman's home and the place where the human

cost of the Light is paid in full. Tonight there is a wake for the three drowned divers and **Maren Coil** is preaching over it; here the players can earn the union's trust, hear the memory-glass speak — a dead mother singing a lullaby to a baby, undeniable and devastating — and find **Pip Harrow** hidden in a back room, glowing faintly, her reflection a half-beat ahead of her. The Ward floods first and worst in the Surge, which is precisely what makes "just stop the harvest" so much harder than it sounds; bring a Snuffer's eye down here and you endanger the girl. Tunnels run from these jetties to the saltworks and to the lake's heart, for those the Ferryman choose to trust.

HOUSE MARROW'S COUNTING HOUSE

This is the brightest, driest, warmest room in Glassmere, and it wants you to know it. An abacus clicks; a music-box turns a drown-song into something pretty; the air is beeswax and mulled wine. Somewhere a young man is drinking alone and too fast.

Money lives here, and so does the lever that can topple Sable without a single dagger drawn: the quota ledger, whose columns prove the draw has outrun the return for thirty years. Tonight **Sered Marrow** hosts a Drown-tide gala, and her guilt-ridden grandson **Aldous** drifts through it like a ghost of the family conscience. The players can charm Sered, turn Aldous, steal the ledger, or buy it at her price; they can learn who profits and glimpse the private shrine to the husband she had Snuffed. The hazard here is social ruin and hired muscle, and a sluice from the saltworks offers one more secret road to the water. Wealth in this house is a moral test dressed as hospitality — every warm, lovely thing in it bought with the same coin as the cold below.

THE ASHEN HOSPICE

Clean white rooms, soft light, river-lilies in a jar. A man sits at a bedside, holding a dying diver's hand while she murmurs to someone who isn't there. Lavender, tallow, and the faint ozone of the nearly-gone.

The hospice is the campaign's quiet center of mercy and the GM's safety valve. **Brother Halve** tends the dying, and

the dying, it turns out, can see through the thinning Veil and speak with the Choir; Halve has heard the truth at a hundred bedsides and kept silent only to let his patients die in peace. He will give the players his journal of deathbed testimonies, the keys to nearly anywhere, a place to hide Pip, and — when the party is stuck — a clue they should already have found, offered so gently it never feels like a handout. Nothing here will hurt them. Everything here will weigh on them.

THE LAKE'S HEART

Past the cold, past the drowned stars of every soul the town has ever kept, a shrine of black oak stands at the bottom of the world, and in its center burns one impossible lantern. Inside the glass is the silhouette of a woman. She is awake. She has always been awake. And the round-song, down here, is finally whole — sung by thousands.

This is the climax, and it is a place, not a cutscene. Mother Vesper waits at the edge of dissolution, the Choir gathered around her, the Veil straining under the weight of the Drown-tide harvest. Here the players learn the whole of it from her own mouth, and here they choose: to undo the binding-knot of her own hair and oar-rope and free her, to stabilize the binding and hold the lights, to take her place, or to refuse. You reach it only by a diver's deep-line, a Ferryman's tunnel, or the refinery sluice — so the door a party comes through is, fittingly, the faction whose hand they took. Play her as a person: tired, kind, dryly funny, three centuries past self-pity. She is the grace at the bottom of the dark, and she will forgive the players even when they cannot forgive themselves.

THE ROADS BETWEEN

Most travel is the open bridges. The cautious can creep the under-quay catwalks and the Drowned-Ward tunnels; the charming can ride an invitation to the Marrow gala or a Conclave audience; the reckless can swim the open lake and pay in cold and mistwights; the cunning can follow the refinery sluice. And one road opens only once it is earned — the Ferryman's deep-line to the lake's heart, which the union surrenders only to those who have won their trust or carried out their memory-glass into the light.

THE PEOPLE YOU'LL PLAY

Each of these is built to come alive in a sentence — lead with the face, the voice, and the line, and reach for the deeper motives only as the players dig.

HIGH LUMEN ORRIN SABLE

Sixty, grey, immaculate, and visibly unslept, Sable is a gentle grandfather of a priest who happens to be carrying

the worst secret in Glassmere. He wants to protect the town, and he hides the truth because he is genuinely convinced it would kill more people than the lie — a conviction that has cost him his sleep and very nearly his soul. He thanks every lamp before he snuffs it; he says, softly, "I am not asking you to forgive me. I am asking you to keep the lights on a little longer." He has knelt at the lake's heart and begged Aldis Vey's pardon and been refused, and

he could have stopped the over-harvest a decade ago and chose the town's comfort instead. Threaten him and he stays calm and calls the Snuffers; win him over and he may give his own life at the climax; expose him and he will not deny a word of it — he will argue, gently, that he was right. Never let him gloat. He should make the players doubt themselves.

LUMEN TÉA WICKHAM

Brisk, warm, and frightened under all that competence, Wickham is the Lamplighter most likely to hire the party — to "find the missing girl, quietly" — because she suspects her own order is hiding something and needs outsiders to dig where she cannot. She rubs the burn-scar on her thumb when she lies, and she lies by omission, because she signed the order that took Pip's lantern and she has already heard the shard of memory-glass she secretly kept. *"I'm not asking you to find a body,"* she tells them. *"I'm asking you to find out why her lamp came home."* Give her cover or courage and she becomes the inside ally who can halt the Vespers; leave her alone and she acts too soon and is caught. She is the conscience of the Conclave, and her arc is the players' own in miniature.

MAREN COIL

Weathered, oar-callused, and magnetic, Maren preaches on the docks with grief balled in her fist. She leads the Ferryman and she means to free the dead before she dies, because as a young Lumen she found the truth and *ran*, and the running has become the engine of everything she does. She carries memory-glass that proves the dead are aware and fire-salts enough to gut the refinery during Drown-tide, and when she says *"They sing in canon so no voice is ever alone — then we put them in a jar,"* she is not exaggerating and she is not entirely safe. Show her a way to free the Choir without tearing the Veil, or remind her of Doran and the living she would drown, and she can be steered; ignore her and she sabotages the harvest mid-festival; corner her and she will try to shatter the First Lantern outright, which frees everyone and floods the lower city in the same heartbeat. Her diagnosis is right. Her cure might kill the patient.

PIP HARROW

Twelve years old, fierce, funny, and faintly glowing, Pip is the missing girl, and her reflection moves a half-beat before she does. She wants to go home and to keep a promise: she met Mother Vesper at the bottom of the lake and swore to *tell*. She is over-lighting and she knows it, and she is more afraid of the Snuffers — and of finishing the change into pure light — than of anything else. *"She's not in heaven,"* Pip says, blunt as a dropped stone. *"She's just really, really tired. She told me to tell you."* Believe her and protect her and she becomes the emotional core of the finale, even able to carry true names down to free the Choir gently; decide things for her and she runs to the heart alone. She is never harmed on screen — her peril is dissolution, not violence — and when the Snuffers come for her, the lake answers on her behalf: lights gutter, water rises.

MOTHER VESPER — ALDIS VEY

At the lake's heart she is a tired, dryly funny old woman made of light, ringed by the drowned stars of everyone she has kept, and she is the grace the whole grim machine has been hiding. She walked into the water to save her town and never thought to ask how long *forever* would be; now she wants two things only — to rest, and to keep her people safe even in the act of leaving them. She will not lie to the players and she will not let them lie to themselves: there is no clean choice, and she will honor whichever they make. *"I walked into the water to save them,"* she says, humming the round-song's missing last note. *"I just never thought to ask how long 'forever' was."* Free her and the lights fail and the Choir lets go like a held breath; re-anchor her and she stays, and forgives them, which is worse. Let her forgive. That is what she is for.

GOODWIFE SERED MARROW

Seventy and sharp as salt, Sered is gracious, generous, and frighteningly practical — a woman who balances books where others break down. She wants Glassmere prosperous and standing, and beneath that she never again wants to lose someone to the Light without knowing why, because she once had her own over-lit husband quietly Snuffed and keeps a shrine to him she will not discuss. She holds the quota ledger as insurance and will part with it at a price; *"Grief is a luxury, dear,"* she says, weighing a salt-coin in her palm. *"I balance books."* Threaten her and she buys, blackmails, or buries you; win her and she is a powerful, unsentimental ally whose money can evacuate the lower city in any flooding ending; ignore her and she funds Sable. Put her grandson at risk, or offer her the chance to be the one who *saved* Glassmere, and even Sered Marrow will move.

BROTHER HALVE

The kindest soul in town, plump and ink-stained, Halve keeps the Ashen Hospice and brews tea for the dying. He has heard the truth from a hundred deathbeds and stayed silent only to guard his patients' peace, and the silence has begun to feel like cowardice to him. *"They all say the same thing at the end,"* he tells the players, pouring. *"It's so crowded down there."* Ask him the right question and he gives you his journal of testimonies, a hiding place for Pip, the keys to nearly anywhere, and the clue you missed — never as a lecture, always as a kindness. He is the GM's gentle valve for a stuck table, and he should never feel like one.

WARDEN CAEL BRISK, THE SNUFFER

Courteous, hard, and very still of hand, Brisk is the chief Snuffer, and he believes he is a mercy-killer putting out fires before they spread. *"I don't hunt people,"* he says, checking his lamp-wick for the hundredth time. *"I put out fires that have started to spread."* He is tired, and he is not sure anymore that he is right; last month he let one over-lit diver flee and cannot say why. Pip is on his list. Show him

that the over-lit can be saved rather than snuffed and he can be turned — the climax solved with a word instead of a blade; corner him and he is lethal and professional. He is the human face of the system's violence: make the table like him, and then make them stop him.

DORAN HARROW

A big, broken man with his daughter's spare lantern always in his hands, Doran is a diver drowning in light-debt and grief. He wants one ordinary morning back, and he has hidden Pip even as the strain and the Snuffers' pressure pull him apart. *"Her lamp came home,"* he says, and his voice goes to pieces. *"Why won't she?"* He is the reason any of this matters — the human weight that turns a clever puzzle into a wound — and he will not let the revolutionaries use his girl, no matter how right their cause.

THE TRAIL OF THE TRUTH

The mystery is built so it cannot dead-end. Every load-bearing revelation can be reached by at least three clues and at least two different *kinds* of clue, and two characters — Brother Halve and Lumen Wickham — exist to hand a stuck table whatever it has missed. Below is the architecture of the secret, written as the players will actually peel it back, with the false reading they may seize first and the thing that finally confirms the truth.

That **the light is made of the dead** is the first wall, and three things crack it: a shard of memory-glass that speaks in a voice that is not its owner's, found in the Underjetty or the reliquary; the way light-preserved food tastes, to the sensitive, of a stranger's last meal; and the old proverb about borrowed light that no one will finish. The comfortable misreading is the sanctioned one — *the dead bless the light* — and the thing that ends the argument is hearing a piece of glass say its own name.

That **the dead are awake and suffering** follows close behind, in Halve's deathbed journal with its refrain of "*it's so crowded down there,*" in a glass shard weeping a lullaby, and in the round-song heard underwater and sung by thousands. The party will want to call it a haunting; the Choir at the lake's heart will teach them otherwise.

That **Mother Vesper is alive in the First Lantern** is the hinge of the whole thing, reached by laying hands on the Hearth-Lantern and feeling her silhouette, by Pip's plain testimony, and by the word of a Ferryman who watched Sable steal down to the heart in secret. *She ascended*, the faithful insist — until the players meet her.

That **the harvest is being over-drawn** lives in numbers: Marrow's quota ledger with its damning columns, the slow dimming of the Hearth-Lantern, and thirty years of suppressed "thin night" records walled up in the reliquary.

Weak faith causes thin nights, says the doctrine; the ledger's draw-against-return puts the lie to it.

That **the hauntings are leakage, not vengeance** is a matter of pattern — the hauntings track the harvest schedule, the reflections lag worst near the refineries, and the Choir never once harms anyone who stops to listen. The fearful read it as the wrath of the dead; the arithmetic of the Veil, laid out at the heart, reads it true.

That **Pip is over-lit and carrying the message** the players can see for themselves: she glows, her reflection runs ahead of her, and the Choir speaks through her. *Possessed*, a frightened mind concludes — until she relays Vesper's exact words.

That **the Snuffers execute the over-lit** in the rite they call the Long Snuff is told by the diver who "retired" and was never seen again, by Sered's hidden shrine, and by Brisk's own haunted evasions; the confirmation is the list with Pip's name on it. That **Sable knows everything** is written in his sleeplessness, in the Ferryman's account of his secret descent, and in his own slip — "*I have asked her forgiveness*" — and is sealed when the players confront him with the ledger or the girl. That **Maren means to blow the refinery tonight** hides in the smuggled fire-salts in the Underjetty, in her too-smooth talk of "only a strike," and in a frightened young Ferryman's eyes; find the charges, or break her composure, and she admits it. And that **freeing Vesper could drown the lower city** is the hardest truth of all, carried in the divers' lore of a torn Veil, in the water already climbing through the floorboards, and in Vesper's own warning — so that *freeing the dead is purely good* is revealed, at the last, as the most dangerous misreading of them all.

HOW THE NIGHT RUNS

This is a one-shot on a clock, not a rail. The minimum path through it is short and reliable: the players hear the water call, follow Pip's lantern to one of the three factions, reach the girl or the memory-glass, learn the truth, get down to the lake's heart before or during the Vesperring, and choose. Everything else — the gala, the reliquary, the deathbed confessions — is texture and leverage layered over that spine.

In a four-hour sitting it tends to breathe like this. The first quarter-hour is arrival and the hook: the festival, the calling water, the still-lit lantern. The next half-hour is the first crisis and the first real choice, as Doran pleads, a Snuffer takes an interest, and three doors swing open — Conclave, Ferrymen, Marrow. From there the better part of an hour goes to investigation and faction contact, the memory-glass and the ledger and the meeting with Pip or

Wickham, as the truth begins to assemble. Around the session's midpoint comes the complication and reversal — a Snuffer raid, Maren's plan laid bare, the ledger surfacing — and with it the dawning of every option's price. Then the point of no return: the Drown-tide Vesperring begins, the Veil tears its first inch, and the players commit to a door down. The finale at the lake's heart runs perhaps three-quarters of an hour, and the last fifteen minutes belong to fallout and epilogue.

The acts each have their own pressure and their own escape hatches. "**What the Water Wants**" asks only that the players commit to looking; if they stall, the lake calls again, louder, or Doran presses Pip's spare lantern into their hands. "**Borrowed Light**" is the assembling of the truth; a stuck table gets a clue from Halve or Wickham, a racing table gets the reversal early. "**The Vesperring**" is the

descent and the choice; whichever road they take, every one of them ends at the heart. The point of no return is the great harvest itself — triggered by Sable's schedule, by Maren's sabotage, or simply by the players doing nothing

— and once it lands, quiet investigation is over: the Veil tears, the water climbs a foot through the whole city, the heart opens, and the only remaining window to free or re-anchor Aldis Vey is open at last.

THE OPENING

The last ferry noses through a field of lanterns. They drift on the black lake by the hundred, by the thousand, each a small patient star, and not one of them is reflected in the water — the surface is too still, too dark, a held breath. Glassmere rises ahead on its forest of stilts, every window warm, the whole city humming a slow round-song that folds back on itself and never quite ends. The air is salt and tallow and river-lily. On the quay, in mourning-white, the people of the town are laughing, because tonight is Drown-tide, and tonight they thank the dead for the light.

A big man pushes through them toward your ferry, a child's small brass lantern clutched to his chest. Behind him, very still, a figure in grey watches the water — and the water, just there, where it laps the pilings, says your name. Quietly. In a voice you know. In a voice you buried.

Doran reaches the rail before the ferry has even touched: "You came in on the ferry — you're not from here, you don't

owe the Light a copper. Please. My girl went under at the Vespering and her lamp came home lit, and they say that's impossible, and they took it, and they're calling her drowned. Please. Will you just look?" A child is missing; a Snuffer, Warden Brisk, is drifting closer, courteous and cold; and at the spot where Pip's lantern beached, a shard of memory-glass lies warm in the planks, murmuring a half-heard lullaby. The lake has said a player's name, and the great harvest is only hours away.

From here the players will choose their first thread, and any of them works. If they answer the water, a reflection that is not theirs rises and mouths *remember*, not *avenge*, and points them toward the place where the dead are heard — the Underjetty. If they help Doran, he offers Pip's spare lantern and a way beneath the quay to people who "know the truth." If they engage the Snuffer, Brisk is polite, warns them off festival rumors, and lets slip that the lantern is being held as "evidence" at the Vesper Hall. Three doors, one truth behind all of them, and a clock already ticking.

SCENES WORTH RUNNING

There are eight set-pieces here, and they span talk, search, dread, hazard, and the wondrous; run them in any order the players' choices dictate. Every one of them moves something — information, a relationship, a resource, the clock, or the shape of the ending.

The Voice in the Water is the hook and the thesis in miniature: at the quay the lake calls a player by a dead loved one's name, and a reflection rises that moves before its owner and mouths *remember*. A read of the moment (Insight, DC 12) finds grief, not malice; the beat costs nothing if refused, but answered it points the way to the Underjetty, and you can give each player their own caller if the table leans in.

The Beaching Spot is the first hard clue, the warm murmuring shard of memory-glass pressed into the planks where the lantern came home (Investigation or Perception, DC 13). The twist is whose voice it carries — Pip's drowned friend, not Pip — which means the dead keep their names. Brisk wants it left alone; palming it past him is a contest against his notice (passive 13), and getting caught only delays things, since Doran has a shard of his own to give.

The Underjetty Welcome is the social gate to the Ferryman, run over a wake for three dead divers with

Maren preaching above it. Trust is the currency; share a real grief and the union opens (Persuasion or Insight, advantage if a character offers a true loss), and the reward is the memory-glass playing a dead mother's lullaby, dive-gear, the offer of the deep-line, and a meeting with Pip. Bring a Snuffer's eye down here and the girl is endangered; sincerity earns the road to the heart.

The Reliquary Under Seal is a quiet heist inside the Vesper Hall, where Pip's lantern and thirty years of buried records sit under Conclave seal. Sneak it, forge a writ, borrow Wickham's key, or use the Vespering as cover (Stealth against passive 14, or Religion to pass as faithful); the wonder and the dread arrive together when a hand on the Hearth-Lantern reveals the silhouette of the woman inside. An alarm turns the scene into a chase or a social crisis; Wickham, won over, can simply cover for them.

The Marrow Gala is intrigue in the brightest room in town, where the quota ledger waits and Sered already knows what it proves. Charm her, turn the guilt-sick grandson Aldous, steal the ledger, or buy it (Persuasion, Deception, or Insight; guards and a social chase if it sours); the prize is the political off-switch for the whole harvest, and perhaps a backer for an evacuation.

The Snuffer's Raid is the night's hardest turn, when Brisk and his wardens come for the over-lit child wherever she's hidden. It can be a fight (Brisk as a **Veteran**, two to four Snuffers as **Guards** or **Spies**), a flight across collapsing bridges, or a conversation, because Brisk does not want to do this and can be talked down. Pip is never killed on screen; the worst case is that she's taken, and the rescue becomes the next beat. Spilled blood here is an omen that hardens the factions and pushes the clock.

The Deep Dive is the descent itself, down the forbidden western water on the Ferryman's deep-line, and it is a

wonder before it is a hazard: the surface gives way to the drowned stars of every harvested soul, and the round-song becomes whole. The cold bites (Constitution saves against exhaustion), the light tugs at the unwary (a Wisdom save or take on a level of "lit"), and the mistwights — **Will-o'-Wisps** and **Specters** — drift in the dark only to *flee* the Choir, revealing that the dead protect the divers. The Surge may begin around the players here; the Choir can calm the water if they've earned its trust.

The Lake's Heart is the climax, and it has a section of its own below — a situation to inhabit, never a boss to beat.

THE OTHER LAYERS OF PLAY

Beneath the set-pieces, three quieter systems give the night its depth. The first is **discovery**: a wandering party finds the truth leaking everywhere — lanterns guttering on a schedule, reflections lagging worst by the refineries, water climbing through the boards, food that tastes of a stranger's last meal, a wall of name-ribbons for the "ascended," a child who counts the planks and frowns because last week there were twelve and tonight there are thirteen. Following the money, the food, or the water always leads somewhere true; watching a Vespering, the sensitive can feel it *pull* something up that screams just below hearing; and the sharpest clue of all is an absence — there are no graves in Glassmere, and no one who "ascends" is ever seen again.

The second is the **social weather**. Light is status and welcome here, and the players will be read by how they carry themselves: question the Light in public and the crowd stiffens and a Snuffer drifts near; share a genuine grief with the Unlit and a name is given in return; flash wild light or memory-glass and you are either arrested or instantly believed, depending on the room; charm the gala and money and the ledger come within reach, at a price; spare or turn a Snuffer and you gain a friend inside the law for the finale; expose the Long Snuff to a crowd and you trade order for outrage. The Unlit, Halve, Doran, and a drunk gala guest will talk freely; Sable, Sered, and Brisk require leverage; the Conclave's clerks lie by reflex. Bribes of forgiven debt and candor work where coin does not, and a public threat against the beloved Conclave will turn the faithful against the players faster than any guard.

The third is **danger**, which is real even when it isn't a fight. The true threat is the Surge — an environmental tide on a clock, not a monster to kill — backed by the mistwights, the cold, drowning, and the slow seduction of over-lighting; the Snuffers are people, and killing them turns the town. Most foes want something other than the players' deaths: the Snuffers want the over-lit contained, the mistwights want the warmth of the living's light, and the Choir wants only to be heard. Fights run short and vertical, over water and slick planks, with lanterns for the only weapon that matters; spilled blood on Drown-tide is an omen that speeds the clock. Think in tiers — a lone Will-o'-Wisp is a nuisance, a Snuffer squad or a knot of Specters is dangerous, and a **Wraith** or the Surge itself is deadly — and reach for the deadly end only as the price of letting the clock run out.

And running through all of it is the **mystery's own spine**: the core question is simply *why did Pip's lantern come home lit?*, and every false lead — vengeful ghosts, weak faith, a girl who merely drowned — still teaches something true on the way to the answer. What truly happened and what the town believes happened are two different timelines, and the fun is in the gap between them. If the players accuse the wrong soul, the error has consequences that loop them back to the truth; if they solve it early, the night simply pivots to its real question, *what will you do?*; and if they never solve it at all, the Choir and Mother Vesper will tell them outright at the heart, and the dilemma lands all the same.

THE CHOICES WITH NO RIGHT ANSWER

Five hard decisions are seeded through the night, each built so that no option is clean. There is **the lantern** — whether to break the truth open in front of the whole festival or hold it to spare the town a panic, weighing honesty against a real and fragile peace. There is **Pip** — whether to re-light her and keep her half-gone among the living, let her finish her change and lose her to her father, or race to free Vesper so the girl can come all the way

home, every path costing Doran or Pip something. There is **Maren's sabotage** — to stop it and prolong the harvest, to let it happen and drown the Underjetty in freeing the dead, or to redirect it to buy time at the heart. There is **Sable's bargain** — light-debt forgiveness for the whole Drowned Ward and safe passage out, if only the players will bury the truth and let one more Vespering run, a genuinely good deal for the poor they have come to love. And there is **the**

anchor itself — to free Aldis Vey and let the lights die so the dead may rest, to re-anchor her and keep the town glowing over her endless imprisonment, or to put a willing soul in her place. Voice the strongest case for every side

through someone the players trust, and let the table carry the weight; the adventure is not asking them to be right, only to choose.

THE RISING TIDE — AN ESCALATION CLOCK

The night tightens in eight turns of the screw. Advance it roughly every half-hour, or whenever the players force a major scene; narrate each turn through light, water, and song rather than announcing it. Harvesting, public confrontation, and spilled blood all push it forward; calming the Choir, delaying the Vesperring, or freeing even a single soul holds it back, and a true moment of remembrance — giving a dead soul its real name — can wind it back a notch. Let it fill and the Veil tears: the Surge floods the lower city.

It opens gently, with **lanterns drifting out** onto the water as the festival begins and the harvest readies — easy movement, easy clues. Then **the water begins to listen**, calling names from the lake as the Veil thins and Pip's danger sharpens; answer a caller kindly and you buy a little time. Comes the **thin night**, lamps guttering in waves and reflections lagging while Vesper weakens and the

Snuffers patrol harder — though a distracted reliquary is easier to crack. Then **the Snuffers move**, a raid or a quiet "retirement" as the cover-up tightens and Brisk is forced to act; turn him or delay him and the screw eases. Next the **water comes through the floor**, the Underjetty flooding ankle-deep as the seam splits and the Ferrymen panic or mobilize; stop the next pull and you slow the rise. Then **the Vesperring begins** — the great harvest, the point of no return, the heart thrown open and Vesper at the very edge, and with it the only window down. Then **the Surge**, the Ethereal tide pouring into the lower city and the Choir spilling through, drowning-into-reflection the new and terrible danger; free or re-anchor Vesper now and it can still be halted. And finally **high water**, when the lower city is taken and dozens will become reflections unless the players' choice at the heart saves them.

TOOLS FOR THE LIVING WORLD

When you need the town to breathe between scenes, roll or pick from these. Each is built to reinforce the mood and leak a little of the truth.

RANDOM EVENTS (D12)

D12 EVENT — WHAT HAPPENS / THE CLUE IT CARRIES	
1	A lamp gutters out mid-street and a child wails. Thin night — the dimming follows a schedule.
2	A reflection in a puddle waves first. The dead are present.
3	A Snuffer "invites" an over-lit diver to walk with him; neighbors look away. The Long Snuff.
4	Ferrymen unfurl a black-cloth oar and call a strike. Faction conflict in the open.
5	The festival "Vesper" actor faints and wakes speaking an old dialect. The Choir is leaking.
6	A peddler offers a cheap blue lamp. Wild light, and a refinery leak.
7	The water rises a hand's width as you watch. The Veil is splitting.
8	A grandmother relights a baby's first-lantern, weeping. What the Light costs a family.
9	A dog barks at the lake until it is dragged away. Something awake below.

D12 EVENT — WHAT HAPPENS / THE CLUE IT CARRIES

- Two Lumens argue quotas, then notice you. The over-harvest, glimpsed.
- A memory-glass shard surfaces and sings a name. Proof, freely given.
- The Hearth-Lantern dims for a heartbeat citywide and everyone feels it. Vesper falters.

RUMORS (D10)

D10 RUMOR (T TRUE · F FALSE · H HALF-TRUE · ! DANGEROUS · * FACTION-PLANTED)

- "Lit lanterns never come home — so Pip can't be dead." (T)
- "The hauntings are the dead, angry we stopped praying right." (F*, Conclave)
- "Sable hasn't slept in a year." (T)
- "Coil drowned a Snuffer and smiled." (H — she let one drown)
- "There's a light you can buy that makes you feel like flying." (T!, wild light)
- "Marrow weighs the dead by the pound." (H — she weighs the ledgers)
- "Drink the festival cider and you'll hear your gran." (H — the over-sensitive do)

d10 RUMOR (T TRUE · F FALSE · H HALF-TRUE · ! DANGEROUS · * FACTION-PLANTED)

- | | |
|----|--|
| 8 | "The Ferryman will blow the lights on Drown-tide." (T*, leaked) |
| 9 | "Mother Vesper still walks the lake on holy nights." (H — she's in it) |
| 10 | "Don't answer the water if it knows your name." (T!) |

COMPLICATIONS (d10)**d10 COMPLICATION — ESCALATES WITHOUT BLOCKING PROGRESS**

- | | |
|----|--|
| 1 | A bridge collapses; cross by skiff or swim the cold. |
| 2 | A Snuffer recognizes a player from the quay. |
| 3 | The memory-glass cracks — one last playing before it's gone. |
| 4 | Fog rolls in and the mistwights stir. |
| 5 | Doran does something rash to save Pip. |
| 6 | Maren moves her deadline up. |
| 7 | A singing, faithful crowd blocks the way. |
| 8 | The water rises a stage early; a room floods. |
| 9 | Sered calls in a favor at the worst moment. |
| 10 | A player who touched wild light starts, faintly, to glow. |

A VOICE FROM THE CROWD (d10 IMPROVISED NPCs)**d10 NAME — ROLE — WANT — SECRET — USEFUL CLUE**

- | | |
|----|---|
| 1 | Wen, ferry-master — wants the last run done — skims fares — saw the lantern beach. |
| 2 | Itta, Sable's page — wants approval — copies sealed records — knows the reliquary code. |
| 3 | Old Garr, diver — wants to retire — is going over-lit — knows the deep-line. |
| 4 | Mistress Vale, ration-clerk — wants order — takes bribes — holds the debt rolls. |
| 5 | Tam, the festival "Vesper" — wants applause — "woke wrong" after fainting — channeled the Choir. |
| 6 | Sister to the Snuffer — wants Brisk to quit — hides an over-lit boy — knows he doubts. |
| 7 | Aldous Marrow, heir — wants to confess — hates the family trade — will hand over the ledger. |
| 8 | Nettle, mudlark child — wants Pip back — hid her once — knows the tunnels. |
| 9 | Goodman Pell, lamplighter — wants to believe — found a "thin night" record — has the over-harvest clue. |
| 10 | The woman in the glass — wants remembering — was someone's mother — is the proof. |

WHAT THE PLAYERS CARRY AWAY

The rewards of Glassmere are light, knowledge, favor, and weight. There is the plain material kind — a Ferryman's skiff, good dive-gear, a purse of Sered's salt-coin, a **Potion of Water Breathing**, a **Lantern of Revealing**, a **Cloak of the Manta Ray** drawn from the companion shelf of SRD gear. There is the social kind: a reputation for "burning clean" that opens the Underjetty and the gala alike, a founder's-right audience, a Snuffer who owes a debt. There are faction favors — the deep-line on call, light-debt forgiven, Marrow's purse opened for an evacuation — and there is forbidden knowledge, the ledger and Halve's journal and the true founding story, each of which is a weapon in the right room.

A handful of things are worth naming. **Pip's still-lit lantern** is a homing light to the heart and a sense for the Veil, but it holds a fragment of the girl, and to lean on it is to risk her dissolution — a compass that is also a conscience. A **shard of memory-glass** will play a dead voice once or twice more before it shatters, an heirloom that ends arguments and starts riots. The **quota ledger** is the political off-switch for the whole harvest, Sable toppled with paper instead of blades. The **Founder's Oar**, Aldis Vey's own, can still the Stillwater for a scene or part the water to the heart, but using it wakes the full attention of the Choir. And a **true name**, once learned, can free a single harvested soul gently and forever — the merciful, partial answer that can never quite free them all.

THE FINALE — THE LAKE'S HEART

The end is a situation to inhabit, not a scene to watch. The Vespering has begun, the Veil is tearing, and the players come down their chosen road into the drowned shrine, where the drowned stars of every kept soul hang in the dark and Aldis Vey turns in her lantern to look at them. "You came all this way," she says, tired and kind. "Sit. Let

me tell you what they did with 'forever.'" Above, the Conclave drives the harvest; somewhere, Maren may be at the refinery with her charges; the Choir gathers; and the Surge climbs with every passing minute. She tells them the whole of it — that she is the keel and the wellspring, that the harvest drains her, that her ending means the Veil's

ending unless something takes her place — and she will not let them pretend the choice is anything but terrible. The wonder is in the faces resolving out of the drowned stars; the dread is in the water beginning to fall *through* the ceiling of the world; and whatever the players decide, something beautiful ends.

They can come at it five ways, and the night has been laying track for each. They can **free her**, cutting the binding-knot, and the lights die and the Choir lets go like a held breath — and the lower city floods unless they have prepared a mercy: the Founder's Oar, an evacuation bought from Marrow, the Choir calmed, true names spent to buy minutes. They can **re-anchor her** and hold the lights, choosing the town over the woman, and she will forgive them for it, which is the heaviest ending of all. They can **replace the anchor**, a willing soul — a player, or Sable in atonement, or Maren, or Vesper freed and then volunteering — taking the keel so the lights live and the dead rest while one person pays forever. They can attempt the hard third road and **reform the harvest**, freeing most and keeping a small, *consented* trickle of volunteer dead,

which demands the ledger, a coalition of factions, and a brutal negotiation with Sable and Maren both — fragile, costly, and the closest thing to hope. Or they can **refuse and walk away**, and let it resolve by default into high water, which is itself a choice with its own weight.

What they did earlier decides what is possible here. Turn Brisk or Wickham and the Vespering can be halted from above; carry the ledger and Sable can be broken or bargained with; ally with Maren and her sabotage becomes a controlled thing that buys time, while ignoring her makes it an uncontrolled blast that worsens the flood. Save and believe Pip and she can carry true names down to free the Choir gently; bring Marrow onside and an evacuation can save the lower city under any flooding ending. The Surge rises each round to press them; Snuffers or Maren may arrive; Pip's change may accelerate if her lantern was overused; and Sable himself may descend, to stop them or to join them. There is no boss to kill — only a tide, and desperate people, and a choice — and a party can win by negotiation, by revelation, by sabotage, by escape, or by sacrifice as readily as by any blade.

How It Can End

Release is the best of the hard endings and still it bleeds: the lights die across the city, the Choir disperses in a wave of peace, the lower city floods but — with preparation — is emptied first; within a week Glassmere is cold and hungry and grieving and *free*, burying its dead by name; within a year a smaller town stands on higher ground, its lamps lit by honest fire. They will say the strangers turned off the light and gave them back their dead, and the players will grieve the ones the Surge still took.

Re-anchor is bittersweet to the point of cruelty: the Surge halts, the lights hold, Aldis Vey stays bound, and the secret passes to a few more aching consciences. The town hails the heroes who saved Drown-tide, and the players never look at a lamp the same way again. **Replacing the anchor** is a pyrrhic grace — a beloved soul takes the keel, the lights live, the dead rest, and a new shrine and a new grief are raised over a new prisoner. **Reform** is the hard-won hope, a fragile coalition holding a town that has become the first to ask its dead for consent, defended now against Sable's and Maren's heirs alike.

The truth itself can surface or stay buried: played for the whole festival on a cracking shard of memory-glass, it brings riot and revelation and the fall of the Conclave; taken in trade for Sable's bargain, it leaves the Underjetty's debts cleared and the comfortable rot intact, and the players carrying what they agreed not to say. A faction may simply win — Marrow's managed prosperity, the Conclave's restored and secret faith, the Ferryman's liberation and hardship. And if the players do nothing, **high water** takes the lower city and dozens become reflections, and a haunted, half-drowned Glassmere learns nothing at all — which is its own kind of hook, should anyone wish to return. There is even a stranger door: a player who steps into the lake and "comes home lit," smiling, and will not say why.

For each ending, play it forward — the morning after, the week, the year — and tell the players what the town comes to say about them, what they themselves come to regret, and what new story is left smouldering for next time.

NOTES FOR THE GM

Run Glassmere consistently and it runs itself: lead every place with light, water, and song, and let every reflection lag a half-beat. Keep the pace honest by narrating the clock through the senses and cutting always to the next choice. When players wander off the map, the Choir's leakage and the rising water will drag the theme back anywhere, and Halve and Wickham are always there to hand over a clue that should already have been found. Give

each NPC a single voice, a single mannerism, and a single line, and they will hold. Escalate by advancing the clock, never by overruling the players' choices.

The night flexes. For a two-hour sitting, open in the Underjetty with the memory-glass already in hand, cut to two locations and the heart, and set the clock at the fourth turn. For six hours, run the full gala heist, a staged descent with a choice at every depth, a subplot for each

faction, and more deathbed scenes. Stretched to three sessions it becomes a mystery, then a week of faction war, then the heart and the new Glassmere. Lean the dread up with the over-lit, the Long Snuff, and a reflection that has begun to act entirely on its own; lean it down by keeping the mistwights distant and the Choir gentle. Reach for

more humor through Pip and Halve and Vesper, for more intrigue through Marrow and the Council, for a more heroic key by making the Founder's Oar and the true names potent enough to save everyone at a personal price — and for a more tragic one by making the lower city's flooding a near-certainty that only sacrifice can avert.

A PAGE FOR THE PLAYERS

Glassmere is a stilt-city on a still black lake, where the dead become the light that keeps everyone warm, fed, and safe, and tonight is **Drown-tide**, the festival that thanks them for it. Everyone knows the Lamplighters tend the Light, that the dead "ascend" into it, that you never let a flame die tonight and never answer a voice from the water that knows your name. Lately the lamps have guttered, the water has risen, and a child-diver named Pip went under at the Vespering — and her lantern came home still lit, which they all swear is impossible.

Wear white to mourn; thank a lamp before you snuff it; offer a guest a lit taper; sing the rounds, but never the last note. Make a character of 3rd to 5th level, any SRD class, who cares about something, and come ready to answer: who have you lost, and what did you never get to say; why are you on the last ferry tonight; and what would you trade your own comfort to protect? This is an eerie, melancholy mystery, more dread than gore. We will set our lines and veils together before we begin.

THREADS TO TIE A CHARACTER IN

For tables that want pre-built hooks, here are eight, each meant to be cut to fit. **The bereaved pilgrim** has come to "give" a lost spouse to the Light and finds the voice already calling their name. **The returned native**, born Unlit and long gone, comes home to settle a debt with the Conclave and to face the ward they abandoned. **The hired investigator** takes Wickham's quiet coin and fears what they'll owe once they know. **The doubting Lumen** is a young Lamplighter losing their faith and desperate for proof they are not a monster. **The diver's kin** carries the

last memory-glass of an over-lit cousin who was "retired" and wants to know what truly happened. **The Marrow black sheep** — Aldous, or one like him — would confess and atone if his grandmother did not terrify him. **The wild-light touched** bought a blue lamp and now glows at the edges and hears the lake, and dreads the Long Snuff. And **the outsider scholar** came to study soul-light for a patron back home who wants it weaponized, and must decide what a soul is worth. Each arrives with a reason to care, a secret to carry, and a stake in how the night ends.

THE ONE-PAGE RUN SHEET

Premise. Glassmere powers its lamps by fishing the souls of its dead from a thin-place lake; a child-diver vanished and her lantern came home still lit, exposing that the Veil is failing. Over one festival night, outsiders must learn the

truth and decide whether a town may consume its dead to survive.

Hidden truth. The Light is refined souls, anchored by the founder Aldis Vey, who bound herself alive into the First Lantern and is being drained to death by over-harvesting;

the "hauntings" are her and the dead leaking back, and tonight's great harvest will push her over the edge and tear the Veil.

The cast. Sable (knows, hides). Wickham (patron, conscience). Maren (radical, has proof and charges). Pip (over-lit child, the message). Mother Vesper (the prisoner-saint). Sered Marrow (ledger, money, guilt). Halve (deathbed truths, clue-refill). Brisk (turnable Snuffer). Doran (grieving father).

The powers. Conclave (harvest, secret) · Ferryman and Unlit (free the dead) · House Marrow (stability, profit) · the Drowned Choir (release, remembrance).

The places. Lantern Quay (hook) · Vesper Hall (lantern and records) · the Stillwater (the dive) · the Underjetty (glass, Pip, deep-line) · Marrow's Counting House (ledger) · the Ashen Hospice (clue-refill) · the Lake's Heart (finale).

The clock. Drift → the water listens → thin night → the Snuffers move → water through the floor → the Vespering (point of no return) → the Surge → high water.

The clues that matter. Memory-glass (the dead are aware) · the quota ledger (over-harvest) · the Hearth-Lantern and Pip (Vesper alive) · the haunting schedule and rising water (leakage and Surge).

The ending menu. Release · Re-anchor · Replace · Reform · Truth exposed or buried · Faction win · High water · the Weird door.

When in doubt. Stuck? A memory-glass surfaces, or Halve speaks a truth. Stalled? Advance the clock and flood a room. Lost? The water calls a name. Fight unwanted? Brisk can be talked down; the Choir scatters the mistwights. Always end a scene on a choice.